

a product. For example, today, Openbravo has been downloaded more than 3 million times across different countries. Just imagine the sheer amount of knowledge this brings to the product. The strong community that evolved around the product brings a lot of maturity to it. Today, Openbravo is being used and localised in more than 20 countries. The community is hugely active in countries like China, Bolivia, Venezuela, Malaysia, Brazil, Italy, Germany, India, UAE, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and many more such nations."

There was another reason for going the open source way. The company is of the opinion that ERP solutions should be accessible to all. The concept of ERP being used only by large companies needed to be changed. Banerjee elaborates, "The SME market is growing at a very fast pace. In this market space, you need an affordable product with great flexibility. We aimed at bringing about that change in the mindset of people. Thanks to the technology and the commitment of our community, today, Openbravo presents a solid platform for all budding companies that do not want to pay a fortune to implement an ERP system within their organisation. Frankly, companies have now realised that open source is not just an alternative, it is one of the most important options."

Open source: The need of the hour

The growth of open source technology is courtesy the current increased technological awareness as well as socio-economic conditions. Gone are the days when companies had a tough time selling open source-based solutions. The awareness has now penetrated even to the lower levels of a company's management team. Commenting on the popularity of open source technology, Banerjee says, "I think we have moved past the time when open source was considered a burden. I have never met a single CEO who is bothered about technology. The reason to implement ERP is to make the business more profitable. So the users are more keen on knowing about the functionalities rather than the technology. In other words, I feel that in the current socio-economic scenario, being open source-based is an advantage that we enjoy."

"Open source has definitely moved from the time when its value was recognised only by the long-haired, rock-loving hackers. Today, even Gartner is predicting the exponential growth of open source-based business applications globally. People have understood the simplicity or the flexibility that open source brings to its user. Some of our largest customers have actually moved from their renowned proprietary systems and opted for Openbravo."

But the road to success was difficult. While the company certainly enjoys the fruits of success today,

there were days when the team had a real challenging time trying to convince people about the basis of their solution. Openbravo chose to stick to open source, maintaining its unique attributes. Banerjee remembers, "The road to this success was not easy. In the initial days, around 2008-2010, I faced some major challenges while proposing this open source solution. I remember someone asked me whether his system could get hacked by anyone if he used open source. I think the issue was a mindset problem. Open source initially spread its wings in the form of UNIX. Those systems were difficult for non-techies to use. I think not many open source companies felt the need to make the system user friendly. So obviously, there were so many myths around the technology. This issue was well identified by Ismael Ciordia, our co-founder, at a very early stage. So as a company, we made a huge effort to make the product simple to use. Today, one of our key strengths is our simplicity."

As far as India is concerned, apart from the enterprises, even SMEs are showing great interest in open source technology, in general. Openbravo claims to have some of the Fortune 500 companies from India as its customers. The ERP solution has spread its wings to sectors like retail, manufacturing, distribution, trading and many more. The company has also entered some niche market spaces like hatcheries, dairy products, manufacturing, jewellery, pharma, retail and construction.

The use of open source technology in Openbravo had resulted in some real good cost savings. Banerjee claims, "The solution is five times more cost-effective when compared to similar proprietary ERP solutions. Overall, the product offers you a lower cost of ownership, thus increasing the ROI to a great extent. Openbravo also offers multiple deployment options such as on the cloud, on-demand and on-premises. The on-premises deployment uses minimum resources while the on-demand and cloud deployment option brings a great saving on the overall pricing of the product."

Interacting with the community: The new age success mantra

A major reason for the success of Openbravo is its interactions with the community. The company considers the community as a 'great strength' for Openbravo. Banerjee says, "We have various forums through which we interact with our community. We also keep sending out periodic mailers updating those interested about the latest developments in the product. We are planning a community meeting sometime in the middle of this year, to have a chance to physically interact with those whom we only connect with online."



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